

**THE BELOVED PAIR**
Fawad Khan and Sanam Saeed in a still from *Barzakh*

A decade back, Pakistani actor Fawad Khan became the poster boy for middle-aged Indian women who swooned over his mature, sensitive portrayals as a dreamy Austen-esque hero in romantic dramas like *Humsafar* and *Zindagi Gulzar Hai*. They'd earn him a break in Hindi cinema with *Khoobsurat* (2014), expanding his fan base among a younger generation. Two more Hindi films would follow—*Kapoor & Sons* and *Ae Dil Hai Mushkil* (2016)—but soon a terrorist attack in Uri would damage the already fraught relations between the two nations. It would ultimately lead to a boycott of Pakistani artists working in India.

"Collateral damage," is how Khan looks at it. "We are in a unique situation where the clash spills over to areas that it shouldn't really," he says. "Having said that, it hasn't stopped the exchange of artistic ideas." *Barzakh*, produced by India's Shailja Kejriwal and Pakistan's Waqas Hassan, is an example of how the creative collaboration continues. The six-episode series is now streaming for free on ZEE5 and the Zee Zindagi YouTube channel.

The much-hyped series marks the return of Khan and Sanam Saeed, the beloved pair of *Zindagi Gulzar Hai* fame. But Khan admits that the show's shippers are in for a surprise. "Sometimes it's really fun to play to the gallery but *Barzakh* isn't that show," he says. "It carefully balances emotions and a sense of surrealism.

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The narrative is different from other series and TV shows. It's intense and complex but at the same time cinematic. It keeps you clued in, [but] doesn't fatigue you."

Written and directed by Asim Abbasi, who helmed the acclaimed Zindagi series *Churails*, the show has been shot in the stunning Hunza valley where an ageing patriarch calls his family members to attend his wedding at his hotel. As Abbasi paints the portrait of a fractured family, he also throws in unrequited love, grief, secrets, magic realism, supernatural elements and more. Khan plays an "unhinged psychiatrist" and a single parent in need of some counselling himself.

For Khan, who slowed his work-rate considerably in the last decade, the show was an opportunity to work with an ingenious creator like Abbasi, one whose visual aesthetic and emotional quotient shines in his works. "His biggest strength is that he writes it himself," Khan says of the filmmaker whose credits include the feature, *Cake*. "You have one mind who can bend the narrative to his visual. He is very thorough; that's why his work shines in a unique way." Abbasi for